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Kidd Jordan

Saxophonist Edward "Kidd" Jordan was born in Crowley, Louisiana and has made his career teaching and performing in New Orleans. He has been on the forefront of progressive jazz in New Orleans and co-founded the Improvisational Arts Quintet. Kidd has shared the stage with Clyde Kerr Jr., Hammiet Bluiett and members of his own musical family.

Kidd was interviewed in Rome, New York on August 24, 2006 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're in Rome, New York filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. I'm really privileged to have Edward "Kidd" Jordan with me today, saxophonist, educator, composer and constant improviser. You were just telling me about your definition of improvisation. Is it something that has to be jazz music?

KJ: No. In fact, I had a little girl, one time I was teaching a class like this. And we had a flutaphone player, and a little girl, we had about three or four of them. You know they're limited. And she was very shy about playing. But when she got started she started improvising of those four or five notes, and I had to just say, "you got it." I mean she played so much after she got started and got it up, and she really was improvising and I mean it was serious. She didn't have any idea about notes or changes or whatever, she was just learning the key — the system of the flutaphone. But when she got started she got all the harmonics out, and the way she was, you know, fingers in different positions. It really was something marvelous to behold.

MR: I'm constantly amazed by the family traditions in New Orleans. And we'll talk maybe later about your children. But was your family, your parents, your siblings, were they as musical as your kids?

KJ: No they wasn't. They, in fact my father now, I didn't come from New Orleans, I came from a little town they called Crowley, Louisiana. And he had some cousins that played. But my daddy used to get, on a Saturday night sometimes when he had a few little drinks in him, he would pick up accordion and try to keep up with them. But they played guitar and bass, his cousins, our cousins. So they had a band but he would try, but if he didn't have a few drinks in him he wouldn't even deal with it at all other than the radio. Now we used to listen to the radio quite a bit. And all my brothers and sisters, there's one time they played in the band, we was in a Catholic school. And they had a very important teacher in my town, Professor O'Jay. He came from the Canadian Conservatory. He was a hell of a trumpet player. And he taught everybody in that area. In fact he taught Illinois

MR: No kidding.

KJ: Illinois. He told me, he say you were my, well the old man was old and he say, "you're my last good student." And he used to tell me, I loved horses. And he used to tell me Illinois Jacquet used to ride from Cade, Louisiana to his house on a horse. And I used to, he'd tell me about Illinois' horse, and I loved horses. I still love them. So he used to tell me about that. And so this is one of the real things, and he'd be hyping me up with Illinois and I'd be playing anything, say hell you so and so and so. So he used that to hype me up with. And then later on I got a chance when I first got the glimpse of playing free was with Illinois Jacquet honking and screaming. See like a lot of people think you know, but when I heard that I said now this could go another way. And I started dealing with freedom you know, like playing free. Because when you're honking and screaming and going on it can give you ideas and at that time the people couldn't play the high notes on the saxophone like we do now. So when I was in high school I could play the high notes on the saxophone, I could play an octave over F. So that would just open the way for me to go on into something else because I was hearing the upper registers.

MR: How did you learn to do that? Did you invent your own fingering?

KJ: Yeah. I had people that used to come to me to write things out for them before — what's his name that put the book out?

MR: Rascher?

KJ: Rascher, Sigurd Rascher, and somebody named Nash. I had a set of fingerings that worked for me when I was in high school with all of that. I just worked them out. I just had a system, I just was hearing high. And I went on. Then when I got to college they wouldn't let me play saxophone 'cause it wasn't a classical instrument, you had to play clarinet. And that broke my heart. And you know what I had to do in order to stop playing it? I took all the pads out of my saxophone. I still got that. I took all the pads out so I could concentrate on clarinet. But fortunately I was with Alvin Batiste who was one of the great clarinet players. So we, you know I started learning and the first semester when I got there in the summer they was laughing at me. And the second year all of them that was there I was on the first seat sitting next to Alvin so I had the last laugh on all of them, so through the rest of my university time I was sitting on the front seat with Alvin because I really put some time in it. And saxophone I would play baritone when somebody needed a saxophone player. Because the school had a baritone. It was for ROTC and we couldn't play on it like we wanted but they would let me take it out on the weekends if somebody needed a baritone player so I could play baritone. And that started me playing baritone. But as far as alto, when I got to maybe my sophomore or junior year after I got established on the clarinet then I used to borrow people's altos to go on and

you know so I could have some extra change. But I got to be a senior and then I was back on my saxophone because I felt like I could, you know I wouldn't have to spend all that time on the saxophone. Because I knew if I had it working then I wasn't going to practice the clarinet.

MR: That's a great story. Like you realized that you were not going to be able to stay away from that saxophone so you had to handicap it.

KJ: Exactly. That's exactly what I had to do.

MR: That's funny. It's interesting, you said you were hearing high. Did it occur to you to maybe play soprano at that time?

KJ: No. They had some — at that time they had some old sopranos, people was giving sopranos away because nobody was playing them. And I didn't even think about playing, because I started out on a C melody. So that's the first thing. But they had old sopranos and stuff around and people weren't, you know nobody was interested in them.

MR: They were out of favor at that time.

KJ: That's right. Bechet was probably the only one playing. And when I came up I didn't come up listening to Bechet, I skipped that generation. I came up listening to Bird.

MR: You came up listening to Bird.

KJ: I came up listening to Bird, yeah.

MR: Okay.

KJ: I mean all of that was there but when I heard Bird I knew that was the real thing.

MR: But when you were let's say ten years old, can you remember what you might have been hearing on the radio?

KJ: Oh the swing things. The big bands. I remember I used to listen and Woody Herman, he used to come from the Left Bank out of somewhere in New Jersey on a Saturday night after midnight. And I would have to go to bed and listen, because my parents, but we would sneak the radio in the room and I would have my head like on one of the things and listen to Woody Herman's band coming from, what is it Left Bank? Because they had that club in New Jersey? I forgot. But I used to listen to Woody coming from the Left Bank at night. And at different other broadcasts at night, he used to bring Basie on every night and Duke Ellington on every night. I caught all of that.

MR: That's terrific.

KJ: But as far as traditional music is concerned I didn't really get into that. I mean they had people playing that but I never did buy it. And then I guess what I was a little — see I was in southwest Louisiana. Now they had bands from down there. Have you ever heard of a trumpet player named Evan Thomas?

MR: No.

KJ: Nobody in your interviews that you ever interviewed said Evan Thomas? [pronounced eVHAN]

MR: Evan?

KJ: Evan Thomas. E-V-A-N. They may have called him Evan Thomas. But out in the country they called him Evan Thomas. He was supposed to be the trumpet player that Louis Armstrong was scared of. They tell me Louis Armstrong was more afraid of him than a pit of rattlesnakes. When Louis Armstrong got to Crowley he would pass it and go by. He was a hell of a player. Now he got killed before I was born but everybody being from Crowley, everybody used to talk about him and I found a picture, somebody gave me a picture in San Francisco last week or the week before last, with him playing in some of the New Orleans band like Pichon's band and all of them. And everybody say he was a hell of a trumpet player.

MR: I bet he's in that, I just read a book by Pops Foster.

KJ: All right.

MR: I bet they mention.

KJ: See if you can find Evan Thomas in it.

MR: Was there a point where you decided, okay I'm going to be a musician. I'm going to make a living as a musician?

KJ: Well there was a point where I decided I was going to be an educator when I went to college. Now all through my college days I played in them bands with leaders or somebody would say I could make a gig, and when I finished college I got a teaching job my first year out and so I've been teaching and playing all my life. I've never made a living as a professional musician, because I got seven kids.

MR: That formula was not going to work.

KJ: That's right. And that's what I tell all the young kids now. You know they say, "I want to be a musician, I'm going to New York, I'm going to do this." I say, "man, get your degree so at least you can have something to fall back on." And I wasn't never in the thing of being a professional musician, my whole thing was teaching and all the gigs and things on the side. And I had too many of them on the side because after I got out of school I started playing in rhythm & blues. Rock & roll was just coming on, so I started playing in some of them, and Fats Domino and them had been the studio or Dave Bartholomew and rock was beginning to really go. And everybody was coming to New Orleans to record. So in the first tier, like Red Tyler and Lee Allen and all of them, they'd be in the studio all day and half of the night, then we could take it at midnight until in the morning. You understand? We were the second tier.

MR: To be a session musician?

KJ: To be a session musician yeah. I mean they would tire them out and all of them. So the second tier and all the people who probably wouldn't be famous was trying to be famous, so they needed a band, so we would be on the second tier. So that was how I made some money in session work. And sometimes people come to me and say, "man I saw your name on a song in England" or something. I don't know. They got the tapes from the — I don't know who in the hell all those people are, I don't have the slightest idea.

MR: Right. It was just like, did you show up and play?

KJ: That's right. That's right. And we had the head. They didn't have any arrangement. We'd put a head arrangement on it and we'd go and put something on it after they started singing.

MR: Was most of that stuff done with everybody there, was it live?

KJ: Oh yeah, you had to do that. And then we had a trick, you make a mistake this time, you make a mistake the next time, and keep going round and round so you'd get overtime. Cause there wasn't no sense in punching in, I mean everything had to go down, the vocalist, the band, the whole rhythm section so everybody had to do it. So we got our formulas for that too, so and all the sessions was union sessions and we had a formula for that also.

MR: That's funny. What would the typical horn section be, a couple of saxes and —

KJ: Oh baritone, [scats] playing the bass line with that, 'cause that was before the electric basses came in you see. I saw the first electric bass I think Monk or one of the Montgomery brothers came through with Lionel Hampton and that's the first electric bass I ever saw. But before, and I tell people before that anybody was a bass player because they'd get on a bass and just slap on, you couldn't hear no changes like formal changes, you couldn't hear nothing.

MR: That's right.

KJ: It could be anybody slapping on the bass man.

MR: Right, they're just picking up the percussive end of it.

KJ: Exactly.

MR: I'll be darned.

KJ: Man everybody played bass in them days. If they had a bass, come on man you can make the gig, you got a bass.

MR: Oh get out.

KJ: I'm serious. But so that's the way that was. So they needed a baritone especially [scats] all them low notes and all that kind of stuff. So baritone could always get a good gig on a session.

MR: What would a session like that pay, do you remember?

KJ: Oh I guess about forty dollars. Union. It came through the union, maybe forty, fifty dollars. So it was all right.

MR: And then how many tunes would you put down.

KJ: Many as you could get in three hour session. A session was three hours. And after three hours you went into overtime. So that's where the money was time and a half or something, that's when you were making a little money.

MR: Well there must have been quite a few mornings where it must have been hard for you to get up with a teaching job.

KJ: Right. It was. It was. But by some hook or crook I did it. I missed a lot of days in the early days though. Because I remember one time they brought it, they said they were going to bring it to the school board say so and so and so, but my band was so good in high school so they just said well man you're not — I said, "let's go. Let's go to the school board and let's get all this out of the way." Because if not I'll get me another job. They said no, no. And after I pushed them to the brink and I knew they wasn't going to do anything I said I've got it made now.

MR: You called their bluff, didn't you.

KJ: That's right. Exactly.

MR: How much did you do, did you teach young kids too, starting?

KJ: Um hum.

MR: How much did you do with developing their ear?

KJ: I used to let them sit down and listen to me practice. I had some kids in high school used to sound like Ornette Coleman. They were — because I was playing alto then. And I was seriously — see at lunch time, when they would come to school on a bus, when they got to school in the morning they heard me standing out in front of the band room doing practicing. And at lunch times sometimes I wouldn't eat lunch, I would practice the whole time. In the evening if they caught the bus if I had to be there for them I was playing my saxophone. And so some of them just gravitated. Number one they started playing the instruments every day, they knew they had to learn all their scales and everything. And my high school band, I had about four or five saxophone players that sounded, in fact they turned out to be some serious saxophone players like Craig Ford and George Peck and some of the rest of them. There were some trumpet players, just by listening and me and opening their ears up. And they was playing rhythm & blues also at high school but I mean they were playing out at that time too. They went on and they went on to college and playing tunes and I was teaching them tunes also. I didn't have a jazz band in high school, but I just was, they would just hear me practicing. I would write little lines out for them to play and they would be playing them, some difficult lines and

they would do it. And some of them was playing all over the saxophone in high school too.

MR: Did the same thing go for your own children? Did they hear you practice?

KJ: They used to hear me practice but then they'd hear their uncle Alvin Batiste practice and it's a funny thing about my kids. They never did — Kent can hear how to play any kind of way. But jazz is such a personal thing that the thing about jazz, there's a whole lot of people want to play a certain way but they don't have the motor skills to play a certain way. They don't have the rhythmic thing in order to play a certain way. This is why I've seen people sit down and learn, I can listen to somebody play sometimes and tell they've got everything correct but they don't have whatever — sometimes it's going against the old system. Like today some of them kids, I was looking and they was on the wrong beat but they was playing it. And like I told the kids about crossing their legs, remember? See all of that is a part of the thing. And I'd rather get a kid who got all of that and we can deal with the other stuff. But you can deal with all that academic stuff and you won't get that and that will be a stumbling block for the jazz thing.

MR: I couldn't agree with you more. I mean you can't teach a kid — you know it's funny the first day, I should tell the people who are watching this that you've been doing a Louis Armstrong camp. And the first day I came down to watch a little bit and you were talking about tough love. And you said Kent knows about tough love. And then today when you were talking about, some of you guys were playing with your legs crossed, you'd better stop doing that or you're going to be limping on the way home. Right?

KJ: Right. Right.

MR: I mean this is serious business, right?

KJ: But you see another thing about my kids, I wanted them to get a good firm grasp of the instrument. So Kent played, I don't know if he told you, Kent played a solo with the orchestra at eleven years old of Mozart. And Marlon, you know Marlon my younger son?

MR: Um hum.

KJ: Marlon played the piccolo trumpet solo in "The Rite of Spring" up there in Tanglewood when he was about twelve years old under Leonard Bernstein. So they was going, and my daughter Rachel, she was going at camp, she went to Tanglewood and Eastman and all of them. I wanted them to get a good grasp of the instrument, a good, well not classical grasp but I mean a good grasp of the instrument, how to play the instrument. See that's another thing with jazz. A lot of people want to play jazz and that's why it's so limited because they don't have the technical facility to go on and do what they're talking about doing. And some people have to spend so much time trying to do some things and they don't have the technical ability, over and over and over, whereas if they'd done their

that I practice jazz. Like it's hard for me to practice sometimes because the reeds are so bad, sometimes I'm in a room fiddling with a reed for three or four hours and my wife says, "well didn't you practice?" "No I haven't practiced, I've been here trying to get a reed to work." And it looks like the reeds are just terrible now. I don't know if you are having any good luck with reeds.

MR: Yeah, you know I use synthetic things.

KJ: Oh you use them. Well I usually use them too but this mouthpiece that I got if I find one that'll work for me one of these days and shave it down. Because I got to shave everything down. This is why I keep the knife in my pocket, I was fooling those kids today. But I got to keep shaving and going on, so that's the problem. But you know she said well how do you do it? But every now and then I'll practice my scales and practice something out here, and then when I get on the bandstand I've just got to come from fresh because the bass player, the drummer and a lot of times I'm playing the pitches of the drums. You see like boom boom boom. And a lot of people say, "man I heard you play, that's great, the pitch of the drums and the cymbal" and that may give me some kind of half, quarter tone or some kind of stuff that I can go around and play against that. All the while when I'm listening and it's really good, like all of that is set up for what I'm going to do.

MR: Wow. I think I heard this on this—

KJ: If you listen, that's a weird tune. And look, when I left this session, the only thing I felt good about was I said at least if somebody hears this they'll know I'm playing in tune with the bells. Somebody will know I got the ear. That's the only thing I love. Because really, after I left this session I said man I should give this guy his money back I feel so bad about it.

MR: The producer you mean?

KJ: Yeah. I said man I should give it, and then he said, "man that sounds good, man we're really excited about this" he called me. And then they sent me a tape of it and it took me about two weeks before I really got into it. I guess it was just a mindset. Because I was looking to do something else and it just took me all the way out.

MR: Well I'm fascinated by, before the camera was rolling you were talking about the session a little bit and you showed up with sort of one thing in mind and the other two-thirds of your trio had something else in mind.

KJ: That's right. Well I was thinking it was going to be like one of the sessions I usually do, we start playing in one of them knock-out drag-out sessions. And we'd get in there and play awful but we'd know, and when I'm with William [Parker] and I'm it I'm going to play off of William and he was going to lay something down for me to play off of so I

free as you think it is. Because William will always lay down some keys, some things, some sounds and then pull it out from under me, and then I've got to go with him and then I get settled again and I have to somewhere else. So I mean it's real improvised. But when I got in there and they started tinkling on the bells and hitting the gongs and the African instruments I said hey man, so and so and so. Now the first part of that was just a warm-up for me to try the mouthpiece. And they put that on there and named that the first one. They kept that. Because I was trying to see how the mouthpiece was going to work. They even kept that one, kept that little part of it.

MR: Okay, so where did the titles come from?

KJ: They named them.

MR: They named them, it's so interesting.

KJ: Well we was eating some chicken legs —

MR: "Last of the Chicken Wings."

KJ: We had some chicken wings and we was in the session. Somebody says, "that's the last of the chicken wings." So they called it and said hey, man, what about it? So they said, "we got that somewhere." So they had it on tape. I don't know if it's on tape here but they had it on tape on the session.

MR: Yeah, it's number seven.

KJ: But I mean the voiceover. Somebody said, "last of the chicken wings."

MR: I think it is on this thing.

KJ: It probably is. So that's how that came about.

MR: That brings me to a question about, you know I think it's easy to misread the intention of musicians sometimes. Like if you listen to some of the later Coltrane records you might think that John Coltrane was really angry or something like that.

KJ: Stark raving mad.

MR: Yeah.

KJ: Some people say he was stark raving mad.

MR: But you made a comment regarding this and someone said, I'm reading from the thing, "the album's turbulent passages almost instinctually call to mind the destructive surge of Katrina." That was this person's thought. But you said that you acknowledged that but with a chuckle. "I was contending with the powerful forces all right but they were my compatriots. They were the guys I was playing with."

KJ: Exactly. That's right. Katrina didn't have nothing to do with that. I wasn't even thinking about Katrina. That was all over.

MR: Okay. So it was a musical response.

KJ: That's right, it was a musical response other than that, that's right. But I'll tell you one

Brooklyn somewhere. It was much more powerful than that because boy we were smoking on that. They were supposed to — maybe they may use it on another record if they can get it because it was in a club and they recorded it in a club. They had, I mean there was one of them knock-out things that William was playing, some of them African instruments in there but it was much more uptempo and out than that.

MR: So when you use the term "knock out drag out" you are talking about really wailing.

KJ: Yeah you know, that's right, what's going on. Like you say Trane stark raving mad. Trane was just into his thing, I mean that's what he wanted to do.

MR: Where did that inspiration for that kind of playing come from? Do you have any idea?

KJ: I haven't the slightest idea, well Trane heard everything. And he heard that the saxophone, like you heard that tune that he did at the Olatunji Center with he and Pharaoh Sanders, that live date that they did at Olatunji Center? I mean that was a hell of a date. I mean they were completely out on that. But Trane was playing on some of the things that he heard the way he put them scales together. I got a good idea how he put all that together. And I talked to Pharaoh about that and he said, "man look, that was just a few Hallelujahs."

MR: It was a what?

KJ: Hallelujah. I mean Trane, you know, and when you get to that point, and I think he was sick because that might have been one of the last recordings. So I mean they just pulled everything out. And I wish I could have been there just to hear it in person, just hearing it the way it is is really, they're really on top of it.

MR: Just physically to pull that off.

KJ: That's right. And him being ill man. I mean that was a hell of a feat. That's right. But you know what? Now Clyde told you about a saxophone player named Alvin Thomas. We played a gig with Alvin Thomas and we didn't know he had cancer. And he told me, he said, man I was up at the thing and he was playing so much at a jazz festival and he said he was going over. And he said it looked like somebody, Trane or somebody, hit him on the back and says, "stand up there." And he stood up and played like there was no tomorrow. And when he came down off the stand we had to stop with him in the car before we got home because the cancer, even though we didn't know he was that ill. So that's some forces that can keep somebody, when you get the energy. I don't know where it comes from but it can keep you going for a minute at least.

MR: Well, look at Lionel Hampton.

KJ: Right.

MR: I mean he'd shuffle out on stage and it would take him five minutes to get across the stage and then you couldn't stop him.

MR: Before I leave this, there was two things I wanted to point out. One that your bass player said, he says if you had an improviser who didn't really have a tone or a sound then this would fail. You have to be familiar with silence and all kinds of sounds to carry this out. He's saying that to play this kind of music you've got to have some juice to your sound already. In other words you were talking about you've got to be able to play your instrument first. That just playing free is not an excuse for lack of technique.

KJ: Oh that's right, that's right exactly. And it's not an excuse for not being able to hear. See that's, when they first started in New York especially, everybody would be going on the stand and trying, twenty or fifteen people just running on and on and over. But when it boiled down and later on as the music kept developing all of those stopped coming on the stand. I mean it started getting to the point where people knew you got to hear in order to know what you're doing, I don't care how out it is. And there's a lot of people still playing free that doesn't — how can it say it — that doesn't come in whatever the chord or whatever the sound is, you can hear that the sound is here and they're somewhere else and never would get to the sound of the tune. And say like beboppers, sometimes there were beboppers like Charlie Parker. Everybody said Charlie Parker played changes. But Charlie Parker didn't play changes like people play changes now like running up the chords or whatever. And that's another thing, when I studied Bird and saw where Bird, when I finally learned how chords was when I was young and finally did Bird, he didn't do any note in the chord. Play a C chord and Bird had an A, an F-sharp, a B-flat. You know all the tops. I didn't know then, but Bird, I knew a C chord and he didn't have a note in a C chord. So don't tell me — you know that's one of the things that kind of turned me off, I said Bird got some other kind of secrets. I said man you're not playing the changes. Well it's a C chord, they don't have an A, before I know a sixth or whatever, he'd have an A, got an F-sharp, a G-sharp, got all kinds of things in it, you understand what I'm talking about. But now, when you hear people saying [scats] spelling out chords, you know, like the real Beboppers, they can play things I mean they can hook all that up and it sounds good, but it sounds like a mechanical kind of thing you know. Now that's good, I don't down nobody for doing it because I hear cats man just sit down and play like that and say wow, they can play "Cherokee" and "I Got Rhythm" and what's another tune, and when I learned those tunes I said I went through that, but when I learned it I said this is good but I don't want to say hey, you know, look at me as a poster child being able to play this because I got the rhythm because the rhythm was straight ahead notes. You know, straight across without anything, and with me I mean I don't want to play that. I don't want to play it. And then, the way I want to play I may jump from the low B-flat to the high F-sharp or D-flat over that, so that's not going to work in

what I alluded to at the beginning. You've got to know how you work, how you are inside and how you work in opposed to how the other people do some things. And like sometimes a guy says, "man you're not playing the changes." I say, "I might not be playing the changes but I'm playing the sound of the song.

MR: The sound of the song.

KJ: Well yeah, the song has a — the tune has a sound. If you play the sound of the tune I mean the changes are just bringing it through the tune. And if they hook up you do that. So if you've got to spell out every chord then you're dealing with a formula. And Bird dealt with a formula but Bird didn't do it like that. And some of them who came after him felt the difference between Bird and Sonny Stitt. Sonny sounded like Sonny Stitt. But Sonny Stitt played one way and Bird played another. I mean what Sonny was dealing with, a lot of people say, but Bird has some extra thing. And then another thing that I peeped a long time ago, that a lot of people play the saxophone, a lot of that music was concocted off of pianos. Bud Powell, you know how Bud Powell and them play?

MR: Yeah.

KJ: And the saxophone was not made up like that. The timbre of the saxophone, the range of the saxophone and all of that has something to do with it. And Ornette always talked about the alto, the saxophone is in the alto clef. Ornette said man the saxophone is not supposed to be played in the treble or the bass clef, it's supposed to be played in the alto clef. And probably that's what he heard and that's why he took and turned that thing around. Now I know you can play other than Charlie Parker played, don't let nobody fool you. Ornette could do that. But he is something else. And the first time he heard me play alto, you know what he told me? He said, "man you play like a bass player, you sound like a bass player."

MR: Really?

KJ: He was talking about the harmonics. See when I was playing all them things up there, he said man — I said, "man, how in the hell you talking about I sounded like a bass," we had a big argument. I said, "if anything I sound more like a violin because I'm playing the violin notes." He said, "no you're playing like a bass."

MR: Like the harmonics a bass player could conceive out of his instrument.

KJ: Yeah. That's right. That's what he told me. So I had to go for it because he was Ornette. He said, "man, look I don't care what you say, you're playing like a bass player." So what else can I say?

MR: It was simply an observation, right?

KJ: Right.

MR: He wasn't telling you to change.

KJ: Oh, well I don't care what he said, it was an observation. But I mean that's weird, I'm playing all them altissimo notes and going up there and playing those things and somebody say, "you play like a bass." Usually you would think a bass would be low. And if you thought about a sound it would be more like a violin. You know. But what he heard — but I could understand what he's saying, the way the bass does and the full strings and the way they do some things he heard something in there. So I had to go along with him.

MR: So going back to college for a minute. You're exploring all these things. You're kind of doing that on your own apart from your education studies.

KJ: Oh yeah definitely. I remember one time they had a big jam session and homecoming, Ellis Marsalis and Alvin Batiste and all of them was down. And I was over at the library listening at John Cage and who else — oh it's slipped my mind — well Stockhausen too but there was a classical composer, Ives, I was listening to Ives. And they thought I was listening to Burl Ives. I said, "Man, I was in the library listening to Ives." "Oh you listen to Burl Ives? What's wrong with you?" So I had to go along with it. So I came to the jam session and I was laughing because I was dead into that. And the last time I saw Louis Armstrong, Louis Armstrong played at the Loyola Field House and John Cage had a concert at Tulane. So I left from John Cage, early in the evening, to catch Louis Armstrong at the field house. So that was a whole day of stuff.

MR: I'll be darned. You have big ears.

KJ: They always was open though. And now I play with the birds in the morning, the birds and the trees. Well at school when the man, dealing with cutting the lawn, I play off of that and all the noises, and sometimes they used to move in the record players, you know how the make a lot of [wails] and I'd get to start playing with them and the people who had ears said man, listen to how he's playing the sound of that. I said that's right. And that's where I'm at, man, now that's really where my music is at. I mean sounds — you know and if they play the sounds I can play it and do something on it. Well that's improvisation. That's on the spot. And I got my ear to the point where I can do it, like the little children was in the gym, I told you, they started running around in sneakers and sliding and making sounds and I was playing it, and they could hear it. And I said that's right, that's where I'm at.

MR: That's great.

KJ: Now whether it's jazz or not, I don't know. I'll let somebody else — I'm improvising. I don't know if it's jazz or not. But if jazz is supposed to be any improvising, all cultures you understand what I'm talking about? All I want to do is improvise, now if you call it jazz, good, you call it something else it's still all right. I don't have no problem with that.

KJ: That's right, they have to, they have to. That's right.

MR: You know Buddy Colette told me that Charlie Parker got his nickname, his version of that story was that he used to play with birds in the morning in Kansas City.

KJ: That probably opened him up. And look, when Kent and them was little, they used to record the birds and bring them in, "Daddy listen to the birds." They'd get up early in the morning and record the birds with a little tape recorder and bring it in for me. So you know how long ago that's been. That's something.

MR: That's so interesting. Let me play something for you here. Maybe it will bring back a memory.

[audio interlude]

KJ: That was Niger.

MR: Yeah. And you played contrabass clarinet on this?

KJ: Right. I'm doing that. That's Buddy Colette was on that session. We did that in Berlin.

MR: I'm curious when I listen to that, how much of the music was actually notated?

KJ: We notated the head. That part of it.

MR: The theme?

KJ: The theme. And then we went on and took it on out. And we came back to the theme as I can remember. That's been a long time ago. But that's probably all we had. Because I brought the arrangement and I know that's all we had. So they took it and went on and did other things with it.

MR: Do you recall if you gave them some harmonic direction or sequence of where to go with this?

KJ: Bluiett, me and Bluiett probably worked with it at a rehearsal because we had done it at Joe Papp's theatre in New York. We played before we went to Berlin. And we probably had some things that we dealt with, with that, in order to juice it up a little bit. But when we got on the gig probably we didn't, you know, everything just fell in place.

MR: Yeah. It sounded like you had that theme going and you had almost two keys at the same time to me.

KJ: Well it was written in fourths at the beginning of the thing and then some of them probably just went on out with it.

MR: It's probably a group that didn't get to play together all that much.

KJ: No we didn't play. That's the only time we played, at Joe Papp's and in Berlin. I think we played about three gigs, maybe twice in New York and once on that festival and that was it.

MR: Well what's it like trying to play what we'll call — for lack of a better term — avante garde in New Orleans.

KJ: Terrible. I've been there. They had — somebody wrote an article on me maybe about eight or ten years ago and said I'm the last free man in New Orleans. And the other day my house was flooded and I happened to run across all that and I sort of picked it up because I had my little grandson, he was a little boy, standing on the side of me. Me and Fred Anderson had played a gig in New Orleans that day and somebody wrote an article saying I was the last free man standing. And my little grandson, he was a little bit of a — so it's hard, see 'cause Clyde and all of them came up under me. They came up, I've had the free — me and Al Fielder, the drummer, Alvin Fielder, we started the IAQ. But there's been a lot of kids that came through SUNO and we've always had free bands but they don't, not too many of them play like that because they can't get any work. So I guess I'm just one of them that was just so pig-headed that I just wanted to keep it going so it's just hard to do. And this year — I played every festival in New Orleans and this year they didn't invite me. I didn't play this year on the last jazz festival. So maybe I might have been the last free man or the last one standing 'cause Katrina may have wiped all of that out and wiped me out too. But you know the thing about it, I've got communities all over, I've got communities in California, Chicago, New York and Europe. So you know I can deal with that. I just got a call today. The cat asks me to come and play with the AACM, just come in solo with the AACM, just come in, just like I do, just get your horn out and walk on the stand and play with us. And we had a good festival in San Jose last week and it was very good. So there's other communities that is opening up. And then I'm getting old, so, older you know, at that age, but I'm really getting old so maybe I need to stop a little bit and just smell the roses.

MR: Do you think that the kind of music you like to play demands more from the listener?

KJ: Right it does. I mean Stockhausen, the man pulled in from Bach and Beethoven and them. But I mean the music just got to keep developing man. And you know I've played gigs in Germany when Stockhausen, before he got too old, he'd be in the front row. And sometimes he'd had his pad, his notation pad. And one time I took one of his pieces and I played on top of it, I said here, take this, this is how your music will sound. Because his sons, one of them played trumpet and one played baritone sax. And they'd always been on the gig and I said here, give it to him, say here take this, this is the way your music will sound when somebody like this is playing on top of it. But I mean it demands something of it. And it takes a while for some — well I mean look at Coltrane, look how long Coltrane's been dead. And if you put on some late Coltrane people will start walking out like you're crazy. I mean right now you know. So how can, you know? And it ain't about, well see another thing with musicians they want to be accepted by the people. They want to be like a hit. How can you make a hit? How you can accept somebody's

people. If you've got that in mind you're not supposed to be in this music. If you want to be accepted like a pop artist and all that. I mean Bird was accepted like a pop artist and all the great players. And Trane was accepted, Ornette's not accepted like that. But so you just have to realize that you're trying to do something and maybe in the next fifty years when I'm long dead and gone maybe somebody may say oh man listen to this, and it might be something. You see what I'm saying?

MR: Do you think people look back to like the Swing Era when that was pop music and think well why can't jazz be popular like it was back then.

KJ: Well you see they was dancing on that. See that's another thing. And Bird and them stopped all of that when they got their turn. That's why Bird had so much trouble, because when they got to the point where they couldn't dance on it anymore it was all over. And that's part of the thing that they had. The music came up, it grew out of people having fun and parties and whatever, but I mean this music here is hard. You're not going to dance on it so you got to listen. And I equate it just like twentieth century classical music. I mean how many orchestras, many of them program one twentieth century piece a year. And two or three, I mean you're really doing something. So I mean and eventually the people are going to get to it and it's going to take a while. You know? And like the composers that I really like I don't get a chance to hear them unless, you know 'cause orchestras don't play them. And not that I don't like Beethoven and all the rest of the people but I mean I want to hear some of the other stuff too.

MR: A lot of it is about selling tickets, isn't it?

KJ: Exactly. And a lot of times a lot of my music sometimes is atonal. I use a twelve-tone system in some of my music. And I practice a lot of it. And you know my daughter always tells me, says, "Daddy you practice on that atonal music but I don't hear it when it comes out on the records." And I say, "cause they don't line it up for me." And then when she say, "you don't ever play nothing you practice." 'Cause I've got some lines that I play on twelve-tone, twelve-tone lines that I can retrograde and do all of that but I try to keep them going and what have you when I'm playing. But if I'm not I haven't got — sometimes they'll set up something for me to hear. But just for me to do it like I practice it, I don't ever do it. Because the way I practice it, for it to come out when it's time for it to come out, if somebody hits something like that that sounds like that, then it will come out. But if they don't ever do it then I won't do it just 'cause I know it. And my daughter, who studied classical music, always tells me that. Say, "why don't I hear something that you're practicing on?" And I say that's just for ear training.

MR: I'll be darned.

KJ: Right. I say that's my ear training exercise.

MR: Interesting. You said something just a second ago and I was trying to remember what it was, it's something about I'm not going to play it just to play it, it's got to fit.

KJ: That's right. I got to hear it. I got to hear how it's going to fit in a certain thing. And sometimes some of the licks, some of the things, like they say, "man you played that lick here and you played that lick there, because that same stimuli came over to me again and I heard that particular thing and it just jumped out without me having any control over it. You know? And like sometimes in minor keys and modes and some things, some stuff just, and, "man you know that's awesome" and I say well it just came out.

MR: Well it sounds like regarding making a living in jazz music, it sounds like you're saying that's almost impossible these days. If you want, because the essence of jazz now is that it's not going to be a hitmaker, so getting back to you tell your students, like you want to make a living as a jazz musician, sort of good luck, but make sure you've got that degree also.

KJ: That's right. Or get you a day job. I mean let's face, I mean I guess like Herbie Hancock and some of them are making a decent living, you know, but how many Herbies they got?

MR: Right. How much room is there at the top.

KJ: That's right. McCoy Tyner and some of them, they do small bands, combos, big bands, they got names. But I mean it takes a while for a kid to come up and make a name for himself and if he may have a hot record, how many of them fly-by-night hotshots came up and you don't know nothing about 'em now. I mean you know. I remember when Dewey Redman's son came up Dewey was saying man my son is so and so and so. And I thought it really was going to effect him one time, he said man my son is doing this and he's a star and so on, he's making it. But now he's cooled off. I mean he's a good player but he done cooled off now, you know what I mean? So they come and they go, I mean it's just like, and records are almost out now because the big recording companies, there isn't any more Impulses and Savoys and all them companies that kept a roster of people playing. They'll give you one or two shots and it's over. You know. And I thank God that it wasn't like that cause we'd have missed all that stuff Coltrane did.

MR: Isn't that amazing.

KJ: That's right, we'd have missed all of that man. Now I can see them dealing with Bird, but when they got to Trane with "Ascension" and all them different guys, you know what I'm talking about?

MR: I do.

KJ: Them kind, well like it is now we'd have missed all of that music man.

MR: You know I have to tell you my own little anecdote when I was coming up in high school and someone said, "well you've got to listen to John Coltrane." I was into Cannonball at

the time. But I went out and got — unwittingly — a Coltrane record and I got "Om." You know? That was a little out for me at that point.

KJ: Right.

MR: Right. I mean you've got to work up to that.

KJ: Yeah but Cannonball was one of my favorite players too. Yeah Cannonball man. And look, changes didn't mean nothing to him, you know that huh? Cannonball played by ear. Did you know that?

MR: Tell me about that.

KJ: Cannonball was playing by ear. I mean he could hear changes like that, and that's why he wasn't locked into all them patterns that people was playing. Well you know Cannonball, and he sounded like a first alto player, that was another thing.

MR: That's for sure.

KJ: That's right. Cannonball could lead us saxes man. I listened to that Cannonball and they're talking about first alto players, as a soloist he's got the same thing that all those first alto players had. You know? And changes didn't mean nothing. Believe me. Cannonball could play through 'cause he could hear 'em. Now that's a case that that's a complete musician. Cannonball could hear anything. And look, before he died he told me he said "Kidd, you know what? I'm going to play some of that crazy stuff, you see the next album I do? I'm gonna do some of the crazy stuff you're doing." But he died before that. Now that would have been something. That's would have been something.

MR: Sometimes you can hear a little bit of that on some of his recordings, just a little.

KJ: That's right. Because you see he came down to New Orleans to do a piece that Alvin Batiste had written for soprano, soprano and alto. And the soprano part was out so he said, "Kidd, you done studied, you know all this" you know how he was. On like the alto they'd be playing all them top register things, he'd go to California and he heard Ernie Watts and them were doing all this, and say, "you know how to do this," you know like all up the horn and the soprano, he hadn't been playing the soprano, but they gave it to him. So I was dealing with the soprano, you know for him to get that stuff 'cause it was written out. And it was a difficult part. And I told him I said, "look, don't worry about it. If you don't get it I got your back, I'll go on and do it with the thing." Shit man we set up that night with Cannon that next morning, he got drunk after it. He drank a pint of whiskey. The next morning he woke up and he had to come with some Maalox to get him up. But Jack, that night, he tore through that on that soprano like Grant went through Richmond. And he told me, "yeah, Kidd, next time watch, I'm gonna do some of the crazy stuff that you're doing," because I had some stuff on tape. And he listened to it. That's the last thing he told me in his lifetime. "I'm gonna do some of that crazy stuff

you're doing." You just wait, I'm gonna get ya. Now if he had done some of that, and the way he is, oh man, Lord have mercy.

MR: It's such a huge sound.

KJ: That's right man.

MR: You know I noticed a slight difference when he used to play, he used to play a King I think, right?

KJ: Right.

MR: And then he switched to Selmer. I could tell.

KJ: You could tell, huh?

MR: I could tell, but—

KJ: He loved that King Super 20. That's what he had. He had a Super 20, he loved that. Then he played the Selmer. That's right.

MR: I think he got an endorsement or something like that.

KJ: But that didn't make no difference because he was going to get it — he could have got the cheapest horn in the world, he was going to get what he heard to get out of it. And as far as changes, believe me, that didn't mean nothing. I mean the cat sat down, he's spelling changes and going oh man look, Cannonball, he heard all of that. He just went on through that.

MR: But he knew them.

KJ: Oh yeah he knew them. But he could hear them. He could hear that. He didn't have to sit down and practice them like them cats do that.

MR: What kind of guy was he?

KJ: Oh easy, happy-go-lucky, I mean one of the most beautiful cats I ever knew. And I got — he and Alvin Batiste was great friends. And me and Alvin was brother-in-laws you know, we've been brother-in-laws for fifty years now, so every time Cannon would come in they'd be cooking gumbo and all, and it would be party time when he'd come to town.

MR: And Nat, you know, contributed a lot to the success of that quintet with his tunes.

KJ: Well Nat was more stable, and you know, he was more the other type than Cannonball. Cannon was just happy-go-lucky, let's have some fun. But Nat was, you know, he was in the business part of it. But I wasn't around Nat as much as that because Nat would be with another crowd when he'd come to New Orleans and Cannonball would be with us you know.

MR: That's a shame he went so early.

KJ: You aren't lying man. But the first time I heard Cannonball we went to Florida A&M, our school went down to Florida and we had a saxophone player by the name of Bert Robinson, I got to get this on your tape.

KJ: Bert Robinson. He was from Shreveport, Louisiana. And Jackie could play just like Ball, I mean just like Bird. And they hooked up that night, you know 'cause Cannonball, he was out of school then but he come back, they had a jam session after the game and the marching band played, so we brought our hero, Bert Robinson. And they hooked up playing man, it was Hella Tella Captain. A lot of people say Cannonball cleaned him out, but I really say Bert Robinson cleaned him out, and Bert is still living. He's in Shreveport, Louisiana. And I tried to get him to start playing again, I told him if he'd start playing again I would buy him a Selmer, but he told me he had a hernia. And he don't want to deal with that and he's way up in his seventies. So he said, "Kidd, I won't play no more." But I was in town doing a workshop with some kids like this, and a little boy was playing something, I forgot what it was but it had a high A on the end. And it took me a while to get him to play it and I called Bert. I said, "Bert, I'm having trouble trying to get this little kid to play the high A." And he told me, yeah, he told me what fingering to use. I said, "you remember that, huh?" And he was playing the high A because he got some of that from me when I got in I was trying to deal with Charlie Parker, you know the way they was playing, but we started extending the range. And he was one of the first ones that started calling me "Kidd." 'Cause they were older, they had come back from the war and said "we don't want this little kid following us around" and so and so and so, and I was the youngest one in the crowd. I went to college real early. And so this little kid's following me so and so and so. So they were calling people say K-I-D. I said the K-I-D is a goof. K-I-D-D is kid. 'Cause all those old men used K-I-D. I said don't associate me with them, I know the Kid Sheik, Kid so and so. I said don't associate me with them. I come from another era, it's younger, put another D on there if you're going to call me Kidd. So that's the way that happened.

MR: You tailored your own nickname. I'll be darned. When you do these week long things at these jazz camps, if you had to prioritize what you want these students to go away with from it, is there a couple of things that you think are really important?

KJ: Well I like to do more than one week so we can get them on some technical things. Go through all the scales and show them how to go from minor scales and playing diminished and half diminished chords and all of that. And to check embouchures and fingerings and all of that. That sometimes I know the teachers tell them this, but when they come from somebody else then they'll always listen. Oh yeah he said so and so and so and so. So I'd rather do that. And have them play something by ear, a lot of stuff by ear, just start making up little stuff, but just have some charts that, like we got, so that the ears is all filled and then we got something. And then let's start giving them, I'd rather write in unison for them and let them start adding parts. See 'cause that's right. And like

And I say all right now y'all got some harmony. And then they start switching off and doing the sections of the saxophone when we was playing. And I say, "don't that sound good?" They say, "yeah it sounds good." And I didn't go through that with the trumpet section, but the saxophone section, even on "River Niger" they had their harmony going. And some other things. And I try not to do this. Just like that tune that you heard Kent spread out on [scats] "Mac the Knife." You heard that chorale, that kind of thing? And I started that out with Kent and them. And Kent and them could hear all kinds of colors and all kinds of moving things. And I said, I listened to them and said, "yeah, that's good." So if I play I can play all of them. With me I don't even worry about colors. Whatever I hear I'm going to do but if somebody puts the colors there then I'll be able to flow through the colors. And I know how that works with them so other kids will come to me, "Daddy, show me this." "I ain't showing you nothing. Find out how to do it" and so and so and so. If you don't do it — I remember Marlon, my younger son, "Daddy write this solo out." He started crying when he was a little boy. "I want to play jazz." I said, "no I ain't going to write nothing out for you." And he'd be sitting up there with the records and I'd run past the room and I'd play the lick. He said, "what?" I said I heard it. I don't know what it is, I heard the lick. I played the lick. And after a while by the time he got in high school he could cop anything off a record. He could hear this and hear that. But I told him I said, "you see that?" You thought I was being really hard on you when you was a little boy, 'cause he wanted to go to school and show off, I knew what he wanted to do. Said, "Daddy please" and went to crying and going on about it and my wife said, "well why don't you write the solo out for him." I said, "no, one of these days he'll remember this and this will be the best lesson I can teach him."

MR: That's a good story.

KJ: And if they stumble over it for a while, and sometimes if you let them stumble, now this is the part of jazz, this might be an important statement, this is the part of jazz that I think isn't happening. They won't let them try enough now, the schools are too lazy 'cause they can go to the teachers and get jazz lessons and learn everything else, learn everything, the solo and all the technical aspects, all the embouchures, all the breathing, everything else is off. And they're going to continue to do that, where if they stumble a while maybe some of them will stumble into a whole 'nother thing. And maybe one of them kids we had today, their rhythm might be messed up and they'll come out with another kind of rhythm to do something, their hearing will bring them somewhere, but if they've got everything written down for them and they're playing it then, you know. Like the average kid now, a cat will say, "man I hear some kids say I'd love to play like Michael Brecker if I could" so and so and so. But they don't know Michael Brecker's got

Michael Brecker they say, "well man, I've arrived now." I say all right, just remember you got Michael Brecker then. Just remember you got Coltrane. Just remember you got Charlie Parker when you get to that point. Your imitation of what they did. So that's the thing.

MR: Who do you think stands out as doing the last really significant thing that changed jazz? A hard question.

KJ: That's a hard one.

MR: I mean has there been someone after Ornette that stands out that has been a real kind of pioneer?

KJ: I really can't think of nobody else done that. I love Sam Rivers. Sam Rivers played some things that, you know, harmonically, Sam Rivers, Ornette, I don't know, man. There's a whole lot of young people that's done things but I haven't come to nobody. Well say like really, I can go back to Monk and all that, there isn't anybody really. Monk did some things that people still have to, you know I mean when he was playing Bebop I mean there's some things that Monk played that still is amazing to me, how he could do that with what everybody else was doing at the time. And there's a whole lot of players. I mean people, and then with me I don't listen to too many records. I can't — that's another thing — I mean they come up with, they may have somebody that's doing marvelous things but I'm so busy trying to do what I do or trying to get myself together and every now and then they say man you hear this so and so and so? But Sam Rivers and Cecil Taylor, William Parker is a bass player that's done some things that's really, you know, listen at it. You know Alan Silva?

MR: I know the name.

KJ: Alan Silva can put some big bands together that can do some marvelous things. I mean some serious things. But I'm just throwing out a few names, I don't know. I don't really know.

MR: Well that was a hard question.

KJ: But they've got a lot of good players out here, the way they're coming up now. I mean they can blow the keys off the horn. They got players can do all kinds of things. And they're making it easy for them so. But now whether they're going to go somewhere else with it or not, that remains to be seen.

MR: That's right, they have to take the next step.

KJ: It takes a while. It takes a while.

MR: I was sorry to hear that you lost some instruments.

KJ: I lost a lot of good instruments man. See I used to be — another part of my life too, I played a lot of shows, see all the Broadway shows that came to New Orleans and big

and Ella Fitzgerald and Gladys Knight, the Four Tops or whoever it was, I was, I do a lot of contracting and I got a friend of mine who used to say I get all the black acts, he'd get all the white acts. And we are very close friends now, I mean we talk all the time. So the hotels and stuff isn't running no more, and I used to play the Fairmont with him in the Blue Room and the acts would come through, and sometimes I'd be on the show if they needed five saxophones I'd always be in there somewhere, four, five and you know.

MR: So you had a lot of horns.

KJ: I had a lot of horns and I was a collector. I've been collecting horns since I had the C melody that I started on. I had that. So I had about three or four C melodies, I had all kinds of altos, I bought a straight alto. I was probably one of the first people in the United States, not from the twenties, they made one from the twenties, I sold that one, I got one of them. But I bought one in Amsterdam that was more in tune than that old one I had. But in fact I've still got a straight, but I had a couple basses, bassoon, about five or six bass clarinets. 'Cause bass clarinets, when you play shows, I would have a bass clarinet in my car in the trunk, maybe two in the locker and one on the stands. 'Cause you can look at them and they go out on you. And I had a friend of mine, he died too, he was an instrument repairman. And I remember many nights going, getting ready to walk on the stand and the bass clarinet was out. I said, "Harris, get my bass clarinet man." "Man, we don't have time." I'd send somebody to the locker. Go to the locker and get one. If that didn't work, get the other one, there's another one in there. 'Cause you know some of them conductors are very picky about them bass clarinet parts and so forth and so on. So I had all kinds of instruments, good quality instruments, and I lost my contrabass that I played on this session that you played from. So I had a lot of instruments and all the saxes, and my wife would look at me — do you know three days I bought a saxophone on a Tuesday, a King Super 20. I went in a pawn shop and saw it, and my wife was over shopping somewhere else. And the man told me what he wanted for it and I told my wife I said, "look I need two hundred dollars." She said, "if you need two hundred dollars it must be a saxophone somewhere." I bought the saxophone on a Tuesday and it had some leaks in it, and I gave it to one of my students, my repairman lived about twenty miles in a community we call Slidell. I said, "bring this to the man and get the leaks out of it 'till it's not leaking and bring it back to school Monday." It was in his car, it went down in his car. But he told me that he thinks the man can fix it. I only played on it with the leaks. And I had another Super 20 that I lost, it was in the attic. And one of my good students, his horns went down. And I had given that to him about maybe a month before that, he had some kind of confusion with his family so I said here take this Super 20, and his horn went down at his family's house so he's still got my old Super 20. And now he asked me,

make him think. I said, "look I may walk down on a gig one night and just say, 'give it to me.'" I will just get mad and keep it.

MR: Keep him on edge a little bit.

KJ: Yeah, keep him on edge.

MR Oh, that's a great story. So did you — you had to evacuate?

KJ: Yeah I had to go to Baton Rouge with Alvin Batiste. He was living in New Orleans, he was working at a house in New Orleans and his home was in Baton Rouge. So we evacuated to his house. We had about twelve people in his house at the beginning. And eventually I got me an apartment I think the second week in Baton Rouge so half of the family moved out and my daughter, she was with me, and then she found an apartment in Baton Rouge. So I'm still in Baton Rouge and I got a trailer in New Orleans.

MR: Well your house —

KJ: My house is completely messed up. Well we were in the process the week before I came of getting some of the stuff out and getting ready to gut it out, you know like cut out where the water — well the water was probably to my waist, about three and a half to four feet. And when I go back next week that's a project that I'm going to deal with. To try to deal with that. And after the hurricane season is over then I'll see about what am I going to do whether I'm going to repair it or sell it or move out. And like my wife wants to go back to New Orleans but I can live anywhere. I could live up here if it wasn't the cold weather. 'Cause somebody, they offered me a gig around Boston but I wouldn't even tell her that because that cold weather, I wouldn't even mention that to her.

MR: You've got quite a list of kids you had as students who have gone on to some great things. That must make you feel pretty good, in addition to your own kids.

KJ: Well the thing about that, it's a double edged sword. The ones that you taught, I don't take credit for none of them because if I take credit for all them I got to take credit for all them who didn't do anything. So when you come to it, yeah they passed through, they got whatever they were supposed to get and some of them, believe it or not, some of them were as good as all the rest of them but they just didn't get the breaks. I know some people that could really play when all of them was on that level. But as you know there was a whole lot of people who came up in our lifetime that didn't get what Charlie Parker got or what Dizzy Gillespie got or so and so and so. And that didn't take away from the fact that they didn't do it. And there's going to always be some people that's going to have notoriety but that doesn't mean the rest of them wasn't able to do it. Because at one point I didn't think Cannonball would get his notoriety. You know? And really when he got with Miles that's when he really blossomed. The first records he made, I mean people, "oh yeah, Cannonball." But after he got with Miles and started dealing with

whole lot of players that went down that didn't do it. So what I tell people, I can't take the credit for you and not take the credit for all the rest of them so there's a lot of them that didn't make it, but I still love them and at the time they were doing what they were supposed to do. And I can understand why some of them say man look I'm going to do this, I'm going to do this, I'm going to do that, and I'll play on the weekends and I'm not going to put all my time into this. And you know that's a part of it, that's all a part of it.

MR: Definitely. Does a student nowadays, an aspiring musician, need to have different skills than guys in the fifties or forties did?

KJ: Oh yeah, definitely. I think they need to know how to write, they need to know how to write scores, they need to get into all of it. And it's easy enough 'cause they got all the computers, like the computers have made a whole lot of people composers. I mean people can sit down and compose and listen at it and what have you. And you've got the notation they can do, I mean it's easy enough. Although I'm not a computer person I'm still writing by hand and still doing all the other stuff, but I mean it made it much easier for them. So you know then they can aspire to write for films and all kinds of things. So I think the generation is going to be much better, but dealing with creative music I think they'll always have that problem. Because the masters had it, they're still having it, and I know in my lifetime and probably a hundred years after my life they're going to be still having it. So it's just a matter of taste I guess. There's always going to be a few, pockets here, pockets there. And like I said some things isn't for everybody. Some things are just for a chosen few. Because when Jesus had his disciples he picked twelve. I mean, it wasn't for everybody, it was just for a chosen few. So some things are just for a chosen few. And when I go and play with the guys, wherever we play, the community, we got a good little community going. So you know I can go and play with them, 'cause they know I'm going to play by ear anyway whatever they got. I can read it if they write it out, I can read it, but sometimes it makes my eyes too bad, I can't do it, I just play. They say "oh man come on Kidd, read the book." You know but it's like I can hear something on it. And I like to do that with kids too because sometimes you write something and they start playing and they hear much better. Even if they're making mistakes. And they don't even hear where there's mistakes and if they're sounding good to me. I remember, I've got to tell you this. When I was teaching in the elementary school I was teaching them the scales. And some of them would play a C scale, then a C scale and a G scale. They would put the F sharp in the C scale. So man I'd be listening to it and it'd be wrong, I'd say wow, listen to this. And you know the story with the Lydian and all that, say yeah, they put the B flat in it and the F sharp and a B flat. I said I wouldn't tell them the difference, I'd just be up there just letting them go. And I'd call and say, "now you've got to learn

just sitting there listening saying "yeah, sounds good to me." So you know out of mistakes. And some of them early kids who I taught that went on and they said, 'yeah man, an F sharp and a D flat." I said, "that's right so now you hear it, you hear how it's supposed to go.

MR: They were already playing it.

KJ: That's right, exactly.

MR: They found a context for it.

KJ: They put the E natural in the B flat scale, yeah man, you got that flat five, raised fourth, and that sounded good. And it went on and it got to be a part of their language. So they'll stumble into some things.

MR: Yeah. You know there's a little quote here on this CD, and I'm not sure you said this but you can tell me.

KJ: I might have forgot what I said.

MR: It says, "very special thanks to all who make this time a joy to be living in." Do you remember saying that?

KJ: I don't remember saying that.

MR: Okay. I didn't know if you said that or not.

KJ: But now there's another thing that I'm really proud of. See that little girl on the cover of that?

MR: Yeah, yeah.

KJ: I was walking and she said, "Mister, you play music?" I say, "yeah." She said, "I would like to know how to sing." So I taught her "Mary Had a Little Lamb" out there and they had a little group of children out there. And that really touched my heart. I stopped and said, "all right listen you want to sing?" She wanted to learn how to sing. And she was so bashful and she was just so withdrawn and when I left I was there about ten or fifteen minutes and she was singing and a whole little group of them were singing, and it felt so good. I said now that really made my day because I was feeling bad about the session. But that made my day. I said now at least, maybe this is what I was supposed to do today. And it felt good and me dealing with kids I mean that's a natural thing. When the little girl said she would want to learn how to sing, and me I would stop and say all right, we're going to sing a song. You want to learn how to sing? I'm going to teach you how to sing. So I started "Mary Had a Little Lamb" and maybe went into some other little nursery rhyme. And she got it down. I said now this is it, this made my day. So I guess that's the teacher's part in me.

MR: I guess so. It's natural for you. Well I want to congratulate you on your 51 years in education.

MR: That's great.

KJ: Going half strong, I'm not strong as I used to be but I'm half strong.

MR: Well in listening to this recording and seeing what you do with the kids, you've still got a lot of energy.

KJ: Well, trying to keep it going.

MR: Yeah.

KJ: Now did anybody tell you about the Humphrey family in New Orleans? You was asking me about musical families.

MR: The Humphrey family, no. Not specifically.

KJ: Nobody told you about the Humphrey family? The Humphrey family was one of them old families. They had a lot of musicians come out of there. The tail end of them, Jamille — he changed his name, he's got a Muslim name now but his daddy was a Humphrey. His daddy's mama was a Humphrey. Daddy was a very good trumpet player, he played with Lionel Hampton and played with M. Red Thompson was his name before he got to be Sharif. He played lead with Lionel Hampton and solo. He's the first person that told me about Clifford Brown and could play all Clifford's solos. He's a hell of a trumpet player, his son is still a trumpet player. And he come from Willie Humphrey that's the Humphrey family, they come out of Willie Humphrey and them. And Willie Humphrey's brother, what was his name? Percy Humphrey. So that was, the grandfather was a musician out toward everybody in St. James Parish. So that was, I know Clyde done told you about some families, but I'll put that down. What about the Adams family?

MR: No.

KJ: They was from across the river. Justin Adams, Placide Adams, and Mama Dolly Adams, and another brother, they come out of a traditional band setting but in the fifties they was playing modern jazz. And they all went back to playing, even the old lady, playing traditional music, that's how they could make a living around New Orleans, you know when they made their comeback, they all started playing again. What about the Bocage family? You even heard of a trumpet player named Peter Bocage? Eddie Bocage?

MR: I've seen it in the books, yeah.

KJ: Yeah there's another family. I went and got some of them old families 'cause I know they talk about all the young ones like the Marsalis' and all of them. But that was three of the old families, along with the Johnson family, I know Clyde talked about him. But that was families that were before.

MR: How do I say this? Would the parents push the kids into music or was it just there all the time and the kids —

KJ: It was there all the time. I tried to discourage mine to tell the truth about it. 'Cause I just

that's why I was sending them to get all that classical technique and all that so they could play some different kinds of music, I said there's enough jazz. 'Cause jazz has — another thing, everybody's not supposed to play jazz. The environment that they put them in, and I tell kids now I say man you better know what you're doing when you want to play jazz. 'Cause I've seen kids that come out of very good families and did this and you see them ten years later and they're out on the streets with all kinds of habits, doing this and doing that and people look at me, I say, "maybe you're not supposed to be in jazz, man, maybe you're supposed to do something else." 'Cause the lifestyle sometimes it'll be too much for them. And people look at me and say, "man why are you discouraging?" I say I'm not discouraging them but I'm letting them know what's ahead because jazz, everybody's not supposed to fool with that. And I know because I've been around people that did everything in the world and I tell them now whatever you do you can die right here on the stand, it ain't going to effect me one bit. You can tell me whatever's going to get you high and make you feel good. I had people tell me said man, the way you could play, with what all you're doing, if you was doing some of them other things, if you had some of this and you had some of that, man you would be the baddest cat in the world. I said yeah, so I don't want to be the baddest cat in the world. I want to be the baddest cat in the world in my right mind. Everything — I'm crazy enough now. I got to be in my right mind at all times. I don't even drink, I can't drink. I mean like they'd go to sip at the bar, anything that gets me out of my mind I mean I just can't deal with it. And I tell people I say man y'all better know what you're doing. It's good and I tell parents, this is good, but you've got to kind of monitor this 'cause when they get out from under your wings and even with the best of training, that outside crowd will take them out. You know, 'cause they get with a hip crowd, just don't be hip. Now I never was hip. That's another thing. I never was a hip cat.

MR: You made your own hip.

KJ: Yeah. Hip cats, I tell them, all the hip cats always fell by the wayside, you know. The slow people are the ones, you know, who make it. But the hip cats that's cause it's going to be hip for a little while and it's all going to be gone. So it's the slow people is the ones who will make it in the end.

MR: Well man that's some great words of wisdom. And I appreciate you sharing it with us. And I'm just kind of—

KJ: You can ask me whatever you want to ask me now, 'cause, you'll say oh man I should have asked him this and I didn't. I know how it is.

MR: Well I'm really happy that we had this conversation and you know the wisdom that you've acquired in your years both in education and in playing really comes through.

KJ: Well and that's what I want it to do. And you know the main thing about it, there's some people I see say, "man, you still teaching school? If I had all the years you had I'd have been retired a long time ago. I say, "man I enjoy what I'm doing." I didn't go to school to sell insurance. I haven't practiced all my life to sell cars. I didn't do this to sit in an office and be an executive now. I'm doing it, exactly what I wanted to do. And if Katrina hadn't come along I wouldn't have retired. They took the music department away. And they wanted me to teach four classes of music appreciation. So you know the music appreciation people, they don't want to be there themselves, that's just cause the university, you've got to take a class in music. You understand? And I used to have one class, and you know I tried to bring up all the music like we talk about now and so forth. And believe it or not they had a lot, every semester in my class they would have somebody who had some famous person in their family and didn't even know them. Like I remember Sidney Bechet's people coming around. I say how the hell? I say man you don't know how great this man is? I say they got a statue of this man in Paris. Say what? You mean to tell me — you know, and both kinds. And what's that other old man, oh man there's a famous old clarinet player, played on "High Society" who was that? Picou. Alphonse Picou. Man, they had people and Picou I said man I was with Picou three weeks before he died. I said that old man was playing when a cast on his arm. Say what? I say y'all just don't know how famous he was. You know what I'm talking about? So I used to use that, say all right, give me the names of the people, let me see who's got somebody, who's your cousin? I found a cousin or a grandfather or something in one of my classes. I said you didn't mean to tell me you didn't know that? And then I would take it and bring them up to that and bring them up to Coltrane and Charlie Parker and bring them to all the classical composers that they didn't hardly ever hear 'cause nobody ever played them, and play it for them in class. And you see all of this is the way the music developed you know? So that's how I dealt with that but I really didn't like it to a certain extent, it was just one class. But you tell me to teach four classes of music appreciation, you know, and well all the instruments went under water, and anything that we had, so that the institution said it would be a while before they get it back up and we were teaching in trailers, so we didn't have a band, in a trailer teaching a band, if we had it was going to be hard, so they cut the music department out completely. So that's when I retired. But I would probably be there now. And I say it when I feel like quitting I was going to quit. 'Cause I was enjoying what I was doing.

MR: Well I'm going to get a handshake in here, because our tape is about to run out.

KJ: With me, I could talk a month. And I told you when I come in I was going to give him everything he needs.

KJ: All right.